Assumption Mapping

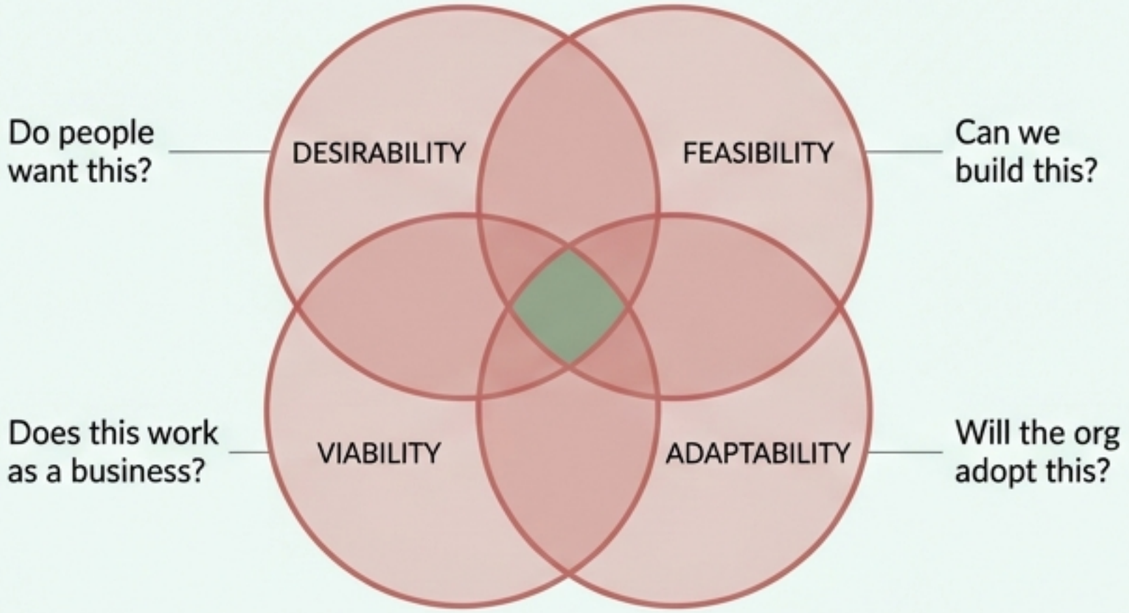
Making the Implicit Testable

Writing down what must be true transforms wishful thinking into testable hypotheses.

Every solution contains hidden assumptions—beliefs treated as facts simply because they have never been questioned. This structured intervention forces teams to extract the implicit, assess the risk, and test rigorously before committing resources.

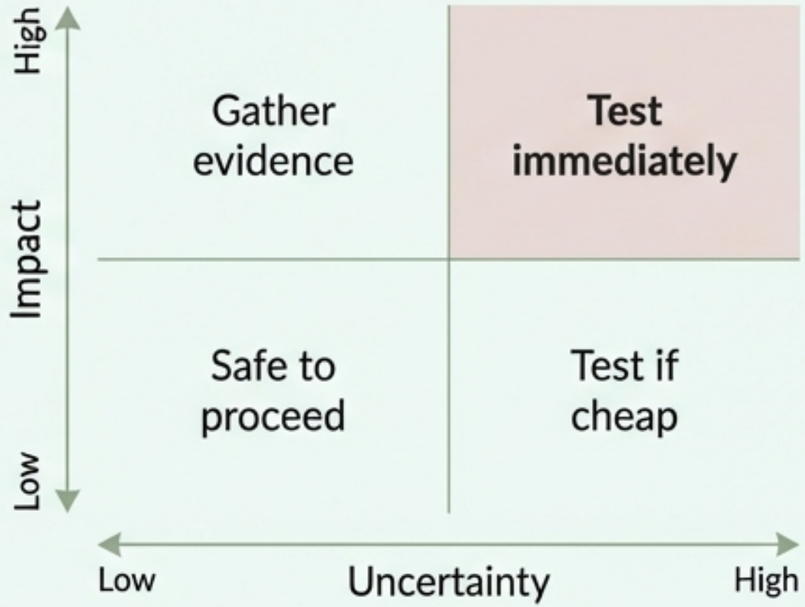
The Assumption Mapping Canvas

"Extract implicit assumptions, make them explicit, assess their risk."



The Riskiest Assumption Framework

Risk = Uncertainty × Impact



- Frame as hypotheses
- Test cheapest first
- Celebrate invalidation
- Keep map visible

1. Generate (5 mins silent work)
2. Cluster (20-30 to 5-8 core beliefs)
3. Assess Risk (plot on 2x2)
4. Prioritise (focus top-right)
5. Design Tests (cheapest/fastest experiment)

Structuring the Test

We believe [..... X].

To test: [..... Y].

Success looks like: [..... Z].

Validated Invalidated Uncertain

Keep the map visible. Update status dynamically as experiments conclude.

The Cost of Knowing

£5k

Cost of learning through early experiment.

Celebrate invalidation. Discovering an assumption is false here saves the project.

£50k+

Cost of discovering post-launch.

The price of treating unverified assumptions as factual constraints.

The goal is not to prove the idea right. The goal is to find the cheapest way to prove it wrong.